

Rhythm & Expression: Indian Performing Arts & Music

NATYASHASTRA, CLASSICAL DANCE FORMS, RAGAS & MUSICAL HERITAGE

The performing arts of India represent one of the world's most continuous and structured traditions of movement, emotion, and acoustic science. Rooted in ancient treatises like Bharata Muni's *Natyashastra* (~200 BCE – 200 CE), Indian dance and music seamlessly integrate aesthetic beauty with spiritual expression.

1. The Theoretical Foundation: Natyashastra & Navarasa

Natyashastra: The Fifth Veda

Composed by Sage Bharata, the *Natyashastra* is a comprehensive ancient encyclopedia covering dramaturgy, stagecraft, music, gesture language (*mudras*), and aesthetics, often termed the *Gandharva Veda*.

The Theory of Navarasa (Nine Emotions)

Indian aesthetic theory centers on evocative emotions: *Shringara* (Love), *Hasya* (Laughter), *Karuna* (Compassion), *Raudra* (Anger), *Veera* (Heroism), *Bhayanaka* (Fear), *Bhibhatsa* (Disgust), *Adbhuta* (Wonder), and *Shanta* (Peace).

2. Major Classical Dance Forms

Bharatanatyam (Tamil Nadu)

Known for its fixed upper torso, bent legs (*Araimandi*), dynamic footwork, and intricate facial expressions (*Abhinaya*). Historically nurtured in temples by *Devadasi* artists.

Kathak (North India)

Characterized by rhythmic footwork adorned with ankle bells (*Ghungroos*), rapid spins (*Chakkars*), and storytelling rooted in courtly Mughal and temple traditions.

Kathakali (Kerala)

A stylized dance-drama featuring elaborate facial makeup, towering headgears, and non-verbal storytelling executed entirely through facial muscle movements and hand gestures (Mudras).

Odissi (Odisha)

Famed for its soft, fluid movements and the signature *Tribhangi* posture—a three-bend stance breaking the body at the neck, torso, and knees, inspired by temple sculptures.

3. The Dual Systems of Classical Music

Hindustani Music (North India)

Influenced by Persian and Central Asian court traditions. Focuses on improvisational exploration of Ragas across distinct vocal traditions (Gharanas) like Dhrupad, Khayal, and Thumri.

Carnatic Music (South India)

Maintains ancient indigenous structural systems centered on devotional compositions (Kritis) by revered saints like Purandara Dasa and the Trinity of Carnatic Music (Tyagaraja, Muthuswami Dikshitar, and Syama Sastri).

4. Acoustic Science of Indian Instruments

Sitar & Veena: Sympathetic Resonance

Instruments like the Sitar feature secondary *Taraf* (sympathetic) strings running beneath the main frets that vibrate autonomously, creating rich harmonic overtones unique to Indian acoustics.

Tabla & Mridangam: Weighted Drumheads

The black central patch (Sahi or Syahi) on Indian drums consists of iron filings, soot, and starch. This precise weighting suppresses harmonic noise and generates clear, pitched musical tones.

Recognized Classical Dances

Dance Form	State of Origin	Key Highlight
Bharatanatyam	Tamil Nadu	Sculptural postures & Araimandi
Kathakali	Kerala	Elaborate face paint & epic drama
Kathak	Uttar Pradesh	Rhythmic spins & footwork
Odissi	Odisha	Tribhangi fluid curves
Sattriya	Assam	Monastic Vaishnavite tradition
Manipuri	Manipur	Gentle circular movements & Raas Leela